Seizing power in a highly centralised system is much easier. When all power is concentrated in the hands of one person, whoever controls access to the autocrat can control the autocrat – and the entire state. To hack the system, one needs to learn to manipulate just a single individual. An archetypal case is how the Roman emperor Tiberius became the puppet of Lucius Aelius Sejanus, the commander of the Praetorian Guard.

The Praetorians were initially established by Augustus as a small imperial bodyguard. Augustus appointed *two* prefects to command the bodyguard so that neither could gain too much power over him.[12] Tiberius, however, was not as wise. His paranoia was his greatest weakness. Sejanus, one of the two Praetorian prefects, artfully played on Tiberius's fears. He constantly uncovered alleged plots to assassinate Tiberius, many of which were pure fantasies. The suspicious emperor grew more distrustful of everyone except Sejanus. He made Sejanus sole prefect of the Praetorian Guard, expanded it into an army of twelve thousand and gave Sejanus's men additional roles in policing and administrating the city of Rome. Finally, Sejanus persuaded Tiberius to move out of the capital to Capri, arguing that it would be much easier to protect the emperor on a small island than in a crowded metropolis full of traitors and spies. In truth, explained the Roman historian Tacitus, Sejanus's aim was to control all the information reaching the emperor: 'Access to the emperor would be under his own control, and letters, for the most part being conveyed by soldiers, would pass through his hands.'[13]

With the Praetorians controlling Rome, Tiberius isolated in Capri and Sejanus controlling all information reaching Tiberius, the Praetorian commander became the true ruler of the empire. Sejanus purged anyone who might oppose him – including members of the imperial family – by falsely accusing them of treason. Since nobody could contact the emperor without Sejanus's permission, Tiberius was reduced to a puppet.

Eventually someone – perhaps Tiberius's sister-in-law Antonia – located an opening in Sejanus's information cordon. A letter was smuggled to the emperor, explaining to him what was going on. But by the time Tiberius woke up to the danger and resolved to get rid of Sejanus, he was almost helpless. How could he topple the man who controlled not just the bodyguards but also all communications with the outside world? If he tried to make a move, Sejanus could imprison him on Capri indefinitely and